

Guide 1 — Ethical Use of Images in Crime Reporting

A practitioner guide for journalists *By Tara Abrahams and Scott Jacques* ·
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Why this guide exists

Crime images carry weight. A single photograph can drive policy, reshape a community's view of a victim, or spread a falsehood faster than any correction can catch it. This guide distills established journalism ethics codes, peer-reviewed research, and current case practice into a short, usable reference for newsroom decisions about visuals tied to crime, policing, and victimization.

It is not legal advice. When in doubt, consult your editor, legal counsel, and—when possible—the people pictured.

1. The four anchors

Before any crime image is captured, used, or published, run it past four questions adapted from the [NPPA Code of Ethics \(https://members.newsleaders.org/resources-ethics-nppa\)](https://members.newsleaders.org/resources-ethics-nppa) and the [SPJ Code of Ethics \(https://www.spj.org/ethicscode.asp\)](https://www.spj.org/ethicscode.asp):

1. **Is it accurate?** Does the image truthfully represent what occurred, in context?
2. **Is it independent?** Were you free of staging, payment, or undue influence by sources?
3. **Does it minimize harm?** Have you weighed the victim's, family's, and community's interests against the public interest?
4. **Are you accountable?** Will you correct, label, or remove the image if facts change—and explain why?

The 2025 NPPA-aligned guidance from the [Center for Journalism Ethics](https://ethics.sjmc.wisc.edu/2026/02/24/photojournalists-call-for-new-ethical-guidelines-to-address-changing-media-landscape/) (<https://ethics.sjmc.wisc.edu/2026/02/24/photojournalists-call-for-new-ethical-guidelines-to-address-changing-media-landscape/>) emphasizes that the long-standing ban on manipulation is necessary but no longer sufficient: today's photojournalists must also navigate restricted access, audience misreading along political lines, AI-generated images indistinguishable from authentic ones, and citizen media that dominates public attention without oversight.

2. Working with crime victims and families

The 2025 Office for Victims of Crime media guide (<https://ovc.ojp.gov/ncvrow2025/working-with-media/advocating-with-news-media>) lays out trauma-informed practices that have become baseline expectations:

- **Approach without equipment first.** Make the human connection before introducing cameras, microphones, or notebooks.
- **Ask permission—every time.** Permission to interview is not permission to photograph; permission to photograph at the scene is not permission to publish.
- **Honor anonymity guarantees rigorously.** Check the published image and caption for any detail (a vehicle, a house number, a reflection in a window, a tattoo) that could identify a source who asked not to be named.
- **Avoid filming victims in distress** unless an overriding public interest exists. Choose images that show resilience and full personhood rather than peak trauma.
- **Re-traumatization is foreseeable harm.** Repeated republication of a graphic image around anniversaries or unrelated stories compounds it.

The 2025 Pulitzer-recognized practice highlighted by [Ethics and Journalism](https://ethicsandjournalism.org/2025/04/23/transparency-accountability-vulnerable-sources-guidance-from-the-2025-collier-awardees/) (<https://ethicsandjournalism.org/2025/04/23/transparency-accountability-vulnerable-sources-guidance-from-the-2025-collier-awardees/>) goes further: keep survivors informed of how their material will be used right up to publication, and be willing to change course based on their late feedback.

3. Recording, publishing, and re-publishing police footage

Body-worn camera (BWC) and citizen footage now drives much crime journalism. Recent peer-reviewed evidence should temper claims that this footage is "objective":

- **Same video, different perceptions.** Cross, Morris, Maguire & Fine (2025) (<https://doi.apa.org/doi/10.1037/lhb0000642>) found viewers' race and political ideology meaningfully changed their procedural-justice judgments of identical BWC footage—especially for ambiguous or unjust events.
- **Verbal framing changes what people see.** Park, Feigenson & Cheng (2024) (<https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1002/acp.700007>) showed that prosecution or defense framing of BWC video led mock jurors to agree with factual statements about the video that were unambiguously false.
- **Camera angle is a point of view.** First-person body-worn perspective tends to shift attribution of responsibility. Treat BWC like any other single source, not as ground truth.

Practical implications for newsrooms:

- Caption BWC clips with what is visible and what is *not* (off-camera audio, before/after the clip, redacted segments).
 - When showing a use-of-force clip, give viewers the full sequence the agency released, not only the most charged seconds.
 - If you draw inferences from the footage (who reached first, what was said), say "the video appears to show..." rather than "the video shows..." when the action is contested.
 - Note retention and release rules. For example, the NYPD's March 2026 policy (<https://www.police1.com/law-enforcement-policies/nypd-tightens-bodycam-policy-to-30-day-release-of-most-critical-incident-videos>) requires release within 30 days of certain critical incidents; Illinois retains footage 90 days (<https://www.bettergov.org/2025/12/17/six-bills-sought-to-reduce-public-access-to-body-cam-footage/>) unless flagged.
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4. Citizen and bystander video

Civilian recording of police is constitutionally protected in the First, Third, Fifth, Seventh, Ninth, and Eleventh Circuits (<https://www.justia.com/criminal/procedure/right-to-record-police-officers/>), and the 2025 Columbia Human Rights Law Review notes the right "remains unsettled and under threat" in others (Rose, 2025 (https://hrlr.law.columbia.edu/files/2025/09/Rose_Codifying-the-Right-to-Record-Police_55.3.pdf)).

When you obtain bystander footage: - **Verify the uploader, location, and time** before publication. Reverse-image search, geolocation, and metadata checks are minimum due diligence (Silverman, 2026 (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NfHEe39AMn4>)). - **Get explicit reuse permission** from the original recorder. A public post is not a license. - **Credit the recorder** unless they request anonymity for safety. - **Do not crop or trim to change meaning.** If you must shorten for time, link to the full clip.

5. AI-generated and manipulated images

The FBI's 2025 IC3 report (<https://www.secureworld.io/industry-news/ai-enabled-fraud-topped-893m-fbi>) logged \$893 million in AI-enabled fraud losses, much of it driven by synthetic images and voices. For crime reporting, the implications are direct:

- **Have a policy and disclose it.** Most newsrooms now publish a clear statement on whether and how AI may touch their visuals. Make yours public.
 - **Label everything synthetic.** If an illustration, reconstruction, or composite is used because no real photo exists, label it on the image itself, not just in the caption.
 - **Run a correction—and pull the image—if AI-altered material slips through.** This is the practice the SPJ recommended in its October 2025 guidance (<https://thespjnews.org/2025/10/17/truth-and-empathy-guide-photojournalism-ethics/>).
 - **Treat user-submitted images as suspect by default** during fast-moving crime stories. Synthetic content is now plausible enough that "it looks real" is not verification.
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6. Crime scenes and graphic content

Ruhl Ibarra and colleagues (2024) (<https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/pdf/10.1080/15205436.2023.2297078?needAccess=true>) found graphic crime images in newspapers cluster on a small number of stories and are heavily shaped by editorial routine rather than consistent ethical reasoning. To bring more discipline to those decisions:

- **Default to non-graphic.** Publish graphic content only when (a) the public interest is concrete and overriding, (b) less graphic alternatives cannot serve the same purpose, and (c) the family has been notified in advance where feasible.
 - **Avoid the "victim-as-evidence" frame.** Do not let the image of a body or wound become the only image associated with a person's name.
 - **Beware the kaleidoscope.** As Higgins (2022) (<https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/14703572221102547>) notes, the same crime can be visually told in five distinct "ways of looking." Be deliberate about which you choose and why.
 - **Mind racial, gender, and class patterns** in your archive. Long-running U.S. research, including Bjornstrom and colleagues (2010) (<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC2904566/>), shows systematic over- and under-representation of certain groups as victims and perpetrators in television crime news.
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7. Newsroom checklist (clip and post)

- [] Have I verified the source, time, and location of every image?
 - [] Did I obtain (and document) consent where required?
 - [] Have I considered the victim, family, and community impact?
 - [] Is the caption accurate, and does it disclose what is *not* shown?
 - [] Is any AI involvement labeled on the image itself?
 - [] If this image is wrong tomorrow, can I correct, label, and explain what changed?
 - [] Would I run this image about someone I know personally?
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Further reading

- NPPA Code of Ethics (<https://members.newsleaders.org/resources-ethics-nppa>)
 - SPJ Code of Ethics (<https://www.spj.org/ethicscode.asp>)
 - Dart Center for Journalism and Trauma — visual journalism resources (<https://dartcenter.org/>)
 - Reuters Institute, *Generative AI and news 2025* (<https://reutersinstitute.politics.ox.ac.uk/generative-ai-and-news-report-2025-how-people-think-about-ais-role-journalism-and-society>)
 - Office for Victims of Crime — 2025 NCVRW media guide (<https://ovc.ojp.gov/ncvrw2025/working-with-media/advocating-with-news-media>)
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Uncertainty flags: research on AI-generated crime imagery is evolving rapidly; specific verification tools and platform policies referenced here may change between updates. Always confirm against the cited primary sources.